MODEL ANSWER KEY
MG5DSCSOC300 — Gender and Sexuality
Fifth Semester | Maximum Marks: 50

Based on the uploaded question paper. 26900509 (1)

Answers to all questions, including alternatives, are provided. Mark allocations are indicative. Equivalent explanations and relevant examples should receive credit.

Part A — Short Answers

Answer any 13 questions. Each carries 2 marks.

1. Expand LGBTQIA+.

- **L:** Lesbian
- **G:** Gay
- **B:** Bisexual
- **T:** Transgender
- **Q:** Queer or Questioning
- **I:** Intersex
- **A:** Asexual; also used inclusively for aromantic and agender identities.
- **+:** Other diverse sexual orientations, gender identities and sex characteristics.

2. Give one example of an ecofeminist issue.

Deforestation and its effects on rural women is an ecofeminist issue. When forests disappear, women responsible for collecting fuel, fodder and water may face increased work and insecurity. Ecofeminism examines connections between environmental exploitation and gender domination.

3. What is work–life balance?

Work–life balance is the ability to manage paid work alongside personal life, family responsibilities, care, leisure and rest without excessive conflict between these areas.

4. Explain measures individuals can take to prevent cybercrime.

Individuals can reduce cybercrime risks by:

- Using strong, unique passwords and multifactor authentication.
- Avoiding suspicious links and never sharing passwords or OTPs.
- Updating devices and reviewing privacy settings.

- Verifying requests before transferring money or disclosing personal information.

Marking: Any four appropriate measures — ½ mark each.

5. Give one example of a changing gender norm.

Fathers sharing childcare and household work is an example. It challenges the belief that caregiving and domestic responsibilities belong exclusively to women.

6. What is a gender stereotype?

A gender stereotype is a generalised belief about the qualities, roles or behaviour expected of people because of their gender.

Example: "Men are naturally better leaders than women."

7. What is reproductive labour?

Reproductive labour is the work required to sustain people and reproduce everyday social life, including cooking, cleaning, childcare and caring for elderly or ill people. It is often unpaid and disproportionately performed by women, although it can also be paid.

8. What is objectification?

Objectification means treating a person as an object for another person's use or pleasure while disregarding their agency, feelings and dignity.

Example: Valuing a woman only for her physical appearance rather than recognising her abilities and choices.

9. Explain measures required for a safe and gender-sensitive workplace.

A safe and gender-sensitive workplace requires:

- Clear policies against discrimination and sexual harassment.
- Accessible complaint procedures, fair investigation and protection against retaliation.
- Gender-sensitisation programmes and respectful communication.
- Fair recruitment, equal opportunities and appropriate facilities.

Marking: Any four relevant measures — ½ mark each.

10. What measures can organisations adopt to improve work–life balance?

Organisations can provide flexible working arrangements, reasonable workloads, predictable schedules, parental and caregiving leave, and childcare support. Respecting employees' time outside working hours also helps reduce work–family conflict.

Marking: Any four explained measures — ½ mark each.

11. Name one agent of gender socialisation.

Family. Through toys, clothing, household duties and expectations, families communicate ideas about appropriate gender roles.

Other acceptable answers: schools, peer groups, media and religious institutions.

12. Describe major provisions of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019.

Major provisions include:

- Prohibition of discrimination in education, employment, healthcare and access to services.
- Inclusive education, welfare and healthcare measures.
- A framework for identity certification, grievance redress and a National Council for Transgender Persons. indiacode.nic.in

Marking: Any two correctly explained provisions — 1 mark each.

Examiner's note: The Act was amended in 2026. If assessing the original 2019 framework, distinguish its original identity provisions from the amended law. dosje.gov.in

13. Define sexual-orientation discrimination.

Sexual-orientation discrimination means unfair treatment, exclusion or disadvantage because of a person's actual or perceived sexual orientation.

Example: Denying a qualified applicant employment because they are gay.

14. Explain legal and social measures for preventing dowry in India.

Legal measures: Enforce the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961, which penalises demanding, giving or taking dowry, subject to its statutory provisions and exceptions. indiacode.nic.in

Social measures: Promote dowry-free marriages, challenge demands disguised as gifts, educate families and strengthen women's economic independence.

Marking: Legal measures — 1; social measures — 1.

15. Define domestic violence.

Domestic violence refers to abusive acts, threats or controlling behaviour within domestic relationships. It includes physical, sexual, verbal, emotional and economic abuse; it is not limited to physical assault. indiacode.gov.in

16. Define intersectionality.

Intersectionality explains how gender interacts with caste, class, race, disability, sexuality and other social relations to produce distinct experiences of privilege or disadvantage.

Example: A Dalit woman may face interconnected caste and gender discrimination that cannot be understood by examining either separately.

Part B — Short Essays

Answer one question from each pair. Each carries 6 marks.

17(a). Explain subordinate and marginalised masculinities with reference to inequalities among different groups of men.

R. W. Connell's approach recognises that there are multiple masculinities and unequal relationships among men. **Hegemonic masculinity** refers to the culturally dominant pattern that legitimises men's dominance and establishes an ideal against which other masculinities are judged.

Subordinate masculinities: These occupy a lower position within the gender hierarchy because they are associated with identities or practices devalued by dominant masculinity. Gay men and men perceived as feminine may face ridicule, exclusion or violence.

Example: A boy mocked for being emotionally expressive experiences pressure to conform to a dominant masculine ideal.

Marginalised masculinities: These arise through the interaction of gender with inequalities such as class, caste, race or disability. Men from disadvantaged groups may be excluded from the authority and resources associated with dominant masculinity.

Example: A working-class Dalit man may face caste and economic exclusion despite being male.

Distinction: Subordination concerns relations of dominance within the gender order, particularly around sexuality and femininity. Marginalisation highlights how other structures of inequality position groups of men.

These categories can overlap. Men may experience disadvantage in relation to other men while still exercising power over women.

Suggested marking: Framework — 1; subordinate masculinity — 2; marginalised masculinity — 2; distinction/conclusion — 1.

17(b). Apply Walby's concept of male violence to interpret restrictions on women's mobility.

Sylvia Walby identifies **male violence as one of the structures of patriarchy**. From this perspective, violence and the threat of violence can maintain unequal power by restricting women's freedom.

Fear as a mechanism of control: Harassment, stalking and sexual violence may make women avoid certain streets, transport services or public spaces. Actual violence against one woman can generate fear among many others.

Family restrictions: Families may respond by imposing curfews, requiring male escorts or preventing women from travelling for education and employment. Responsibility for avoiding violence is thereby placed on women.

Institutional restrictions: Colleges, hostels and workplaces may impose stricter movement rules on women. Such practices can normalise unequal access to public space.

Economic consequences: Restricted mobility may prevent women from accepting distant jobs, working certain shifts or participating in professional activities.

Application: If a student is prevented from attending evening classes because of harassment on her route, Walby's concept reveals how male violence indirectly limits her educational opportunities.

The appropriate response is to hold perpetrators accountable and improve safe access, rather than make women's confinement the solution.

Suggested marking: Walby's concept — 2; application and mechanisms — 3; conclusion — 1.

18(a). Explain the effects of the gender-based wage gap on women and their families.

The **gender wage gap** is the difference between women's and men's earnings. It reflects factors including occupational segregation, unequal care responsibilities, differences in working hours and discrimination. It is broader than unequal pay for identical work.

Reduced economic independence: Lower earnings can increase women's dependence on partners or relatives and reduce their ability to make independent decisions.

Lower household resources: Families have less income available for food, housing, healthcare and education. This is particularly serious in households dependent on women's earnings.

Reduced bargaining power: Lower earnings may weaken women's influence over household spending, residence and employment decisions.

Cumulative disadvantage: Reduced earnings limit savings, property ownership, retirement contributions and financial security in later life.

Reinforcement of unequal care roles: When women earn less, families may decide that women should reduce paid work to provide care. This can further reduce their experience and future earnings.

Effects on children: Financial insecurity can restrict children's opportunities. Persistent wage inequality may also reinforce expectations that men's work is more valuable.

Example: A family may ask the lower-paid mother to leave employment when childcare becomes expensive, deepening her long-term disadvantage.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; explained effects — 4; example/conclusion — 1.

18(b). Explain the relevance of liberal feminist principles for improving women's access to education.

Liberal feminism emphasises **equal rights, individual freedom and equal opportunities**. It argues that gender should not determine access to education or the ability to develop one's talents.

Equal admission opportunities: Girls and women should have fair access to schools, colleges, training and all fields of study.

Removal of discriminatory rules: Institutions should eliminate practices that restrict subjects, activities or leadership roles according to gender.

Material support: Scholarships, affordable education, transport and accommodation can help remove practical barriers to participation.

Freedom of choice: Women should be able to choose subjects and careers according to their interests rather than gender expectations.

Gender-sensitive teaching: Textbooks, classroom interactions and career guidance should challenge assumptions that particular abilities belong to one gender.

Institutional reform: Accessible grievance procedures, protection against harassment and support for students with caregiving responsibilities can improve retention.

Example: Supporting women's participation in engineering through fair admissions, financial assistance and mentoring puts liberal feminist principles into practice.

Liberal feminism provides a strong basis for educational reform, although formal equality alone may not overcome deeper caste, class and gender inequalities.

Suggested marking: Principles — 2; educational applications — 3; example/assessment — 1.

19(a). Explain dowry violence with reference to harassment connected with marriage payments.

Dowry violence refers to abuse, coercion or harassment connected with demands for money, property or valuable goods associated with marriage.

Continuing demands: Harassment may occur when an agreed payment is considered insufficient or when new demands arise after marriage.

Forms of violence:

- **Physical:** Beating, assault or other injury.
- **Emotional and verbal:** Insults, humiliation, threats and repeated criticism of the woman or her family.
- **Economic:** Confiscating earnings, withholding necessities or pressuring her family to transfer property.
- **Coercive exclusion:** Threatening abandonment or expelling her from the marital home.

Social basis: Patriarchal entitlement and the treatment of marriage as a status transaction can encourage the belief that the bride's family owes continuing payments.

Consequences: Dowry harassment can produce injury, distress, debt, isolation and, in severe cases, death.

Example: A woman is repeatedly threatened and assaulted because her parents refuse a post-marriage demand for a car.

The Dowry Prohibition Act addresses marriage-connected dowry demands. Prevention also requires social rejection of coercive payments and support for affected women. indiacode.nic.in

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; forms and mechanisms — 3; consequences — 1; example/prevention — 1.

19(b). Analyse legal and policy protections in an educational institution's response to discrimination against a transgender student.

Discrimination against a transgender student should be treated as a violation of equal participation and dignity, rather than as a problem with the student's identity.

Legal foundation: Section 3 of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act prohibits discrimination in educational establishments and their services. Section 13 requires government-funded or recognised institutions to provide inclusive education and equal opportunities in sports, recreation and leisure. indiacode.nic.in

Receive and address the complaint: The institution should provide an accessible reporting process, document the complaint and investigate promptly and fairly.

Prevent further harm: It should stop bullying, exclusion and retaliation and provide appropriate academic or counselling support.

Restore equal access: The student should have fair access to classes, examinations, scholarships, facilities and extracurricular activities.

Respect identity and privacy: Institutional practice should use respectful communication, protect confidential information and avoid unnecessary disclosure of the student's transgender status.

Review institutional policies: Anti-discrimination rules should explicitly address gender identity. Staff training, inclusive teaching and consultation with transgender students can help prevent recurrence.

Example: If a student is excluded from a college event because they are transgender, the institution should restore participation, investigate the exclusion and correct the rule or practice that enabled it.

Suggested marking: Legal foundation — 2; institutional response — 3; application — 1.

20(a). Discuss patriarchy as an explanation of restrictions on women's mobility.

Patriarchy is a system of social relations through which men, as a group, hold disproportionate power and women face systematic disadvantage. It operates through families, economic institutions, cultural norms and public life.

Control of sexuality: Restrictions on movement may regulate women's friendships, relationships and partner choices.

Family honour: Women's behaviour is often linked to family reputation. Families may impose curfews or require permission for travel while allowing men greater freedom.

Gendered division of labour: The expectation that women should remain responsible for domestic work can limit participation in employment, education and public activities.

Economic dependence: Lack of income, transport or control over resources can make women dependent on others for movement.

Violence and intimidation: Harassment in public spaces and abuse at home can discourage independent movement.

Institutional reinforcement: Unequal hostel rules or restrictions on women's travel can reproduce patriarchal assumptions.

Example: Allowing a son to travel for higher education while requiring a daughter to remain at home demonstrates unequal expectations based on gender.

Restrictions also vary by caste, class, age, disability and location. A patriarchal analysis shows that mobility involves access to resources and decision-making power as well as physical movement.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; mechanisms — 4; example/conclusion — 1.

20(b). Explain how difference and plurality contribute to an inclusive gender programme.

Difference recognises that people have varied identities, circumstances and needs. **Plurality** recognises that there are multiple gender identities, experiences and viewpoints rather than one universal experience.

These ideas improve gender programmes in the following ways:

Avoiding a single model: A programme should not assume that all women—or all people of any gender—face the same problems.

Recognising intersecting inequalities: Caste, class, disability, sexuality, religion, age and location can shape access and participation.

Including diverse identities: Programmes should enable meaningful participation by transgender, non-binary and other gender-diverse people.

Adapting support: Different barriers may require different responses, such as accessible venues, childcare, local-language materials or transport assistance.

Sharing decision-making: Participants should help identify priorities, design activities and evaluate outcomes.

Assessing unequal outcomes: Evaluation should examine who benefits and who remains excluded, rather than relying only on total participation.

Example: An employment programme could combine skills training with childcare for caregivers, accessibility support for disabled participants and measures against caste and gender discrimination.

Difference and plurality therefore support substantive equality: people receive the conditions needed to participate with dignity and agency.

Suggested marking: Concepts — 2; applications — 3; example/conclusion — 1.